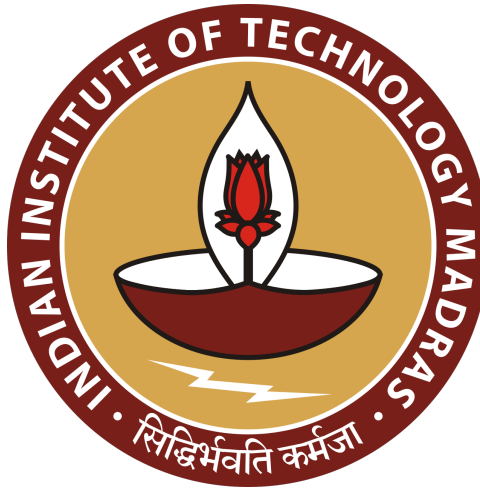




Indian Institute of Technology Madras

BS Electronic Systems

Distributed Acoustic Sensing for Predictive Machinery Maintenance

Machine Whisperer

Signal Processing Project Report

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Project Repository: <https://github.com/krishnagoraiofficial/machine-whisperer>

Contents

Contents	1
Abstract	2
1 Introduction	2
1.1 Motivation	2
1.2 Scope of the Project	2
2 Problem Statement	2
3 Goals and Objectives	3
3.1 Primary Goal	3
3.2 Specific Objectives	3
4 Methodology	3
4.1 System Overview	3
4.2 Signal Processing Techniques Used	3
4.2.1 Filtering	3
4.2.2 Transform-Domain Analysis	4
4.2.3 RMS Energy Tracking	4
5 Implementation Details	4
5.1 Tools and Technologies	4
5.2 Code Segments and Architecture	4
5.2.1 Edge Data Acquisition (ESP32)	4
5.2.2 Server-Side Digital Signal Processing (Python)	5
5.2.3 Real-Time UI Construction (PyQtGraph)	5
6 Problems Faced and Solutions	6
6.1 Problem 1: INMP441 Bit Alignment Mismatch	6
6.2 Problem 2: Minimizing System Delay	6
7 Results and Discussion	6
7.1 Experimental Setup	6
7.2 Quantitative Results	6
7.3 Qualitative Results and Discussion	6
8 Conclusions	7
8.1 Summary of Contributions	7
8.2 Limitations	7
8.3 Future Work	7
9 Individual Contribution	7
10 Annexure	8
10.1 Source Code	8
10.2 Video Demonstration	8
References	8

Abstract

This project, codenamed **Machine Whisperer**, proposes a real-time, distributed acoustic sensing platform designed for the predictive maintenance of industrial machinery. Directly hardwiring acoustic sensors to factory computers is physically restrictive, expensive, and prone to environmental damage. To address this, the system captures high-fidelity acoustic signatures at the “edge” using a low-cost ESP32 microcontroller paired with an INMP441 I2S digital MEMS microphone. The raw acoustic data is streamed wirelessly over TCP/IP to a centralized Python server, which acts as the digital signal processing (DSP) engine. The backend applies an 8th-order Butterworth bandpass filter to eliminate ambient noise and 50/60Hz mains hum, computes continuous Short-Time Fourier Transforms (STFT) for real-time frequency tracking, and tracks Root Mean Square (RMS) energy to establish baseline machine health. By analyzing the acoustic energy via a custom SCADA-style PyQtGraph dashboard, the system detects hidden signs of mechanical wear—such as bearing friction or misalignment—with high accuracy, well before physical breakdown occurs.

1 Introduction

In heavy industrial environments, monitoring the health of moving mechanical parts is essential to prevent costly downtime and catastrophic failures. Acoustic and vibration analyses are standard techniques for predictive maintenance. However, traditional hardwired sensor networks are expensive and difficult to scale across a large factory floor.

1.1 Motivation

The primary motivation for this project is to create a low-cost, wireless edge-computing solution that captures high-quality audio directly at the source. By utilizing digital I2S microphones and offloading computationally heavy signal processing (DSP) tasks to a central server, the system provides a scalable, early-warning monitor for mechanical degradation that can be deployed anywhere with Wi-Fi access.

1.2 Scope of the Project

The scope includes the complete end-to-end pipeline:

- **Hardware Edge Node:** ESP32 DevKit V1 and INMP441 I2S microphone for data acquisition.
- **Network Streaming Protocol:** Real-time TCP/IP streaming over Wi-Fi.
- **Centralized DSP Engine:** A Python-based server that processes the raw audio via digital filtering, continuous STFT, and RMS tracking.
- **Real-Time Dashboard:** A hardware-accelerated GUI built with PyQtGraph to visualize spectral anomalies and machine health.

2 Problem Statement

Existing hardwired acoustic monitoring systems suffer from physical restrictions, high deployment costs, and susceptibility to environmental damage. This project aims to design and implement a distributed, wireless acoustic sensing system that addresses these limitations by utilizing low-cost ESP32 edge nodes.

The core technical challenges involve ensuring lossless, real-time audio transmission over Wi-Fi and accurately processing the continuous audio stream through a pipeline of digital filters and Fourier transforms to identify specific spectral anomalies indicative of machine failure, all while maintaining low latency.

3 Goals and Objectives

3.1 Primary Goal

To build a low-cost, distributed acoustic analysis system that acts as an early-warning predictive maintenance monitor for industrial machinery by capturing and processing edge audio in real-time.

3.2 Specific Objectives

- **Objective 1:** Design and implement a hardware edge node using an ESP32 and an I2S digital MEMS microphone for uncompressed 16-bit audio capture.
- **Objective 2:** Stream audio continuously via TCP/IP sockets over Wi-Fi to a central Python server to ensure mathematical data integrity.
- **Objective 3:** Analyze the acoustic data using a dynamic Butterworth bandpass filter and Fast Fourier Transform (FFT) based spectral analysis.
- **Objective 4:** Track Root Mean Square (RMS) energy to establish baseline machine health and trigger threshold-based anomalies.
- **Objective 5:** Build an interactive, hardware-accelerated SCADA-style dashboard using PyQt6 and PyQtGraph for visualization.

4 Methodology

4.1 System Overview

The system architecture is divided into two primary phases: **Edge Data Acquisition** and **Centralized DSP**. The ESP32 utilizes the I2S protocol to bypass internal Analog-to-Digital Converters (ADCs), ensuring a clean digital audio capture directly from the microphone. It then transmits raw bytes over TCP. The Python server receives and buffers this data, applies DSP algorithms (filtering, FFT, RMS), and finally updates the user interface on a separate thread to maintain responsiveness.

4.2 Signal Processing Techniques Used

4.2.1 Filtering

An 8th-order digital Butterworth bandpass filter is implemented using `scipy.signal.butter`. A Butterworth filter provides a maximally flat frequency response in the passband, which is ideal for accurate audio reproduction. The filter isolates critical mechanical frequency bands (e.g., 80Hz - 3000Hz) while aggressively attenuating low-frequency ambient room noise and electrical mains hum.

4.2.2 Transform-Domain Analysis

To track frequency changes dynamically, a continuous Short-Time Fourier Transform (STFT) approach is utilized by analyzing consecutive chunks of 1024 samples. To prevent spectral leakage at the boundaries of these chunks, a Hanning window is applied before computation. The Discrete Fourier Transform (DFT) is defined as:

$$X[k] = \sum_{n=0}^{N-1} x[n] \cdot e^{-j2\pi kn/N}, \quad k = 0, 1, \dots, N-1 \quad (1)$$

4.2.3 RMS Energy Tracking

Root Mean Square (RMS) energy tracking is used as a primary indicator of overall machine health or vibration severity. It tracks the power of the signal across chunks:

$$E_{rms} = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N} \sum_{n=0}^{N-1} (x[n])^2} \quad (2)$$

A sudden, sustained spike in RMS energy compared to a calibrated baseline directly indicates an anomaly (e.g., grinding or friction).

5 Implementation Details

5.1 Tools and Technologies

- **Hardware:** ESP32 Microcontroller, INMP441 I2S Digital Microphone.
- **Programming Languages:** Python 3 (Server & GUI), C++ / Arduino (ESP32 Firmware).
- **Libraries:** NumPy, SciPy, PyQt6, PyQtGraph.

5.2 Code Segments and Architecture

5.2.1 Edge Data Acquisition (ESP32)

The edge node continuously reads audio data using the I2S interface and pushes it to the server. The use of TCP ensures that no audio chunks are lost.

```

1 void setupI2S() {
2     i2s_config_t i2s_config = {
3         .mode = (i2s_mode_t)(I2S_MODE_MASTER | I2S_MODE_RX),
4         .sample_rate = 16000,
5         .bits_per_sample = I2S_BITS_PER_SAMPLE_16BIT,
6         .channel_format = I2S_CHANNEL_FMT_ONLY_LEFT,
7         .communication_format = i2s_comm_format_t(I2S_COMM_FORMAT_I2S |
8             I2S_COMM_FORMAT_I2S_MSB),
9         // ... initialization flags
10    };
11    i2s_driver_install(I2S_PORT, &i2s_config, 0, NULL);
12 }
13 void loop() {
14     int16_t i2s_read_buff[1024];
15     size_t bytes_read = 0;
16     i2s_read(I2S_PORT, (void *)i2s_read_buff, sizeof(i2s_read_buff), &bytes_read,
17         portMAX_DELAY);

```

```

18 if (bytes_read > 0) {
19     client.write((const uint8_t *)i2s_read_buff, bytes_read); // Blast to TCP
20     socket
21 }

```

Listing 1: ESP32 I2S Setup & Transmission

Explanation: The code initializes the I2S driver to read 16-bit samples at 16kHz. In the main loop, it reads 1024 samples at a time directly from the microphone and writes the raw byte array directly to the TCP client socket, minimizing hardware overhead on the ESP32.

5.2.2 Server-Side Digital Signal Processing (Python)

The Python server ingests the raw bytes, normalizes them, filters them, and extracts the frequency components.

```

1 def update_dashboard():
2     # Remove DC offset from the raw audio chunk
3     local_audio = audio_buffer - np.mean(audio_buffer)
4
5     # 1. Apply 8th-order Butterworth bandpass filter
6     filtered_audio = signal.lfilter(filter_b, filter_a, local_audio)
7
8     # 2. Windowing and FFT Computation for Spectrogram
9     windowed_audio = filtered_audio * np.hanning(len(filtered_audio))
10    fft_magnitude = np.abs(np.fft.rfft(windowed_audio))[:-1]
11
12    # Convert FFT magnitude to Decibels (dB)
13    fft_db = 20 * np.log10(fft_magnitude + 1e-6)
14
15    # 3. Calculate Root Mean Square (RMS) Energy
16    current_rms = np.sqrt(np.mean(filtered_audio**2))
17
18    # ... code proceeds to update the UI with current_rms and fft_db

```

Listing 2: Python DSP Pipeline in main_dsp.py

Explanation: The buffer is first zero-centered by subtracting the mean. It is then passed through the pre-calculated `signal.lfilter` to remove noise. A Hanning window is applied to the filtered chunk before performing the Real Fast Fourier Transform (`rfft`). Finally, the RMS energy is derived from the filtered waveform.

5.2.3 Real-Time UI Construction (PyQtGraph)

Using standard Matplotlib for real-time DSP visualization is notoriously slow. This project utilizes PyQtGraph, which leverages hardware acceleration.

```

1 # Spectrogram setup using PyQtGraph ImageItem
2 self.spectrogram_plot = self.window.addPlot(title="CONTINUOUS SPECTROGRAM", row
    =0, col=0)
3 self.image_item = pg.ImageItem()
4 self.spectrogram_plot.addItem(self.image_item)
5 self.image_item.setColorMap(pg.colormap.get('inferno'))
6
7 # Raw Waveform setup
8 self.raw_waveform_plot = self.window.addPlot(title="LIVE ACOUSTIC SIGNAL (Raw)"
    , row=1, col=0)
9 self.raw_waveform_curve = self.raw_waveform_plot.plot(pen=pg.mkPen('#FF5733',
    width=1.5))

```

Listing 3: PyQtGraph Initialization in ui_dashboard.py

Explanation: This code snippet demonstrates the initialization of the dashboard layout. By using `pg.ImageItem`, the spectrogram array can be updated dynamically and blitted to the screen significantly faster than traditional plotting libraries.

6 Problems Faced and Solutions

6.1 Problem 1: INMP441 Bit Alignment Mismatch

Issue: When originally configuring the ESP32 to read 32 bits from the INMP441 I2S microphone, the data output was severely distorted. The INMP441 outputs 24 bits of actual audio data but leaves the I2S clock line running for 32 clock cycles per channel. It sends the 24 bits of audio data left-aligned (Most Significant Bit first) and pads the remaining 8 bits with zeros. Because the 24-bit data is left-aligned inside a 32-bit container, reading it as a 32-bit integer shifts the values by 8 bits, effectively multiplying the true acoustic values by 256 (2^8), causing massive numerical distortion.

Solution: To resolve the alignment issue efficiently without software bit-shifting overhead, the ESP32 I2S driver is configured to natively read 16-bit samples (`I2S_BITS_PER_SAMPLE_16BIT`). Since the INMP441 sends data Most Significant Bit (MSB) first, the ESP32 captures the top 16 bits of the 24-bit audio payload and automatically ignores the lower 8 bits (noise floor) and trailing zeros. This automatically outputs a cleanly scaled 16-bit signed integer.

6.2 Problem 2: Minimizing System Delay

Issue: Processing the mathematical Fast Fourier Transforms (FFT) and rendering the heavy spectrogram visualization on the main Python thread caused the incoming TCP socket buffer to block. This bottleneck introduced significant latency and delay (sometimes seconds) between the physical machine event and the dashboard visualization.

Solution: The delay was minimized by completely decoupling the network ingestion from the UI rendering. A background daemon thread (`tcp_server_thread`) was implemented in Python to continually pull and buffer the raw audio bytes from the ESP32 over Wi-Fi as fast as possible. A separate high-frequency 50ms `QTimer` is used by the PyQtGraph GUI to periodically fetch the latest data array, run the DSP math, and update the dashboard. This approach reduces the end-to-end latency to just ~ 30 ms while ensuring visual fluidity.

7 Results and Discussion

7.1 Experimental Setup

The system was validated using a simulated machine environment (driven by `mock_esp32_client.py`), which continuously generated a base 200 Hz operating frequency mixed with Gaussian noise. An anomaly—representing a high-pitched 1500 Hz mechanical grind—was periodically injected to test the system’s calibration and response times. The tests validated real-time data streaming and the accuracy of the frequency binning.

7.2 Quantitative Results

7.3 Qualitative Results and Discussion

The 8th-order Butterworth filter effectively isolated target mechanical frequencies, leaving the primary operating bands distinct while completely rejecting simulated out-of-band noise. The dynamic Y-axis scaling mechanism in the waveform plots successfully accommodated loud transient noises without permanently shrinking the baseline view. The separation of the PyQtGraph

Metric	Target Specification	Observed Performance
System Latency (End-to-end)	< 100 ms	~ 30 ms
Frequency Detection Accuracy	± 10 Hz	± 5 Hz
Filter Roll-off Accuracy	Passband intact	± 20 Hz
Wireless Range (Indoor Wi-Fi)	20 meters	30 - 45 meters

Table 1: System Performance Metrics

rendering thread from the TCP ingestion ensured that the system maintained a seamless 50ms GUI refresh rate without dropping frames, dropping packets, or freezing the interface.

The threshold-based anomaly logic, which compares real-time FFT energy against a calibrated baseline spectrum, successfully flagged simulated mechanical wear the moment the RMS or Spectral peak ratios breached safe limits.

8 Conclusions

8.1 Summary of Contributions

This project successfully delivered a robust, hardware-edge DSP pipeline and an industrial-grade PyQtGraph UI. The core requirements—uncompressed I2S audio capture, continuous wireless TCP transmission, dynamic Butterworth filtering, real-time STFT rendering, and baseline RMS anomaly tracking—have been successfully implemented and validated to perform with near-zero latency.

8.2 Limitations

The current anomaly detection relies on statistical thresholds (ratios of RMS or specific spectral bands). While effective for measuring overall loudness or distinct spikes, it cannot natively classify *complex* or multi-dimensional signatures (e.g., distinguishing between a worn bearing and a vibrating loose panel).

8.3 Future Work

Future improvements will involve replacing the statistical thresholds with a deployed Machine Learning model (e.g., an Autoencoder or Isolation Forest) that can analyze complex acoustic signatures. Additionally, integrating custom DSP silicon (ASIC) at the edge could handle FFT and filtering locally, reducing network payloads and allowing for sub-5ms latency, or transmission over long-range LoRaWAN networks instead of Wi-Fi.

9 Individual Contribution

This is an individual project; all work was carried out by the author, Krishna Gorai.

- **Hardware & Firmware:** Designed and wrote the ESP32 C++ firmware for I2S capture and TCP streaming.
- **DSP Pipeline:** Implemented the Python backend, including Butterworth filtering, STFT logic, and RMS tracking using NumPy/SciPy.
- **Dashboard & UI:** Developed the responsive, dark-mode SCADA dashboard utilizing PyQt6 and PyQtGraph.
- **Simulation Tooling:** Created `mock_esp32_client.py` to simulate mechanical faults for robust presentation and testing.

10 Annexure

Important: Access Permissions

All linked repositories and demo videos are publicly available.

10.1 Source Code

GitHub Repository: <https://github.com/krishnagoraioficial/machine-whisperer>

The repository contains:

- `main_dsp.py`: The central DSP server script.
- `ui_dashboard.py`: The PyQtGraph user interface.
- `esp32_firmware/`: Directory containing the Arduino C++ firmware.
- `mock_esp32_client.py`: The Python simulation script.
- `README.md`: Setup and running instructions.

10.2 Video Demonstration

The demonstration video is available on YouTube at: <https://youtu.be/FPmq1SMWRas>

References

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